It was the first day of November 1858 when Queen Victoria issued a direct proclamation to Indians explaining that Company Rule was over. She promised to provide her Indian subjects with similar rights as British subjects. For the great many Indians and sepoys who had fought on the side of the Company and their British colleagues during the rebellion, the words and promises of the British queen were a great comfort. The British Raj began thenceforth, with faith and confidence on both sides. The 82-year-old Emperor Bahadur Shah Zafar was convicted of conspiracy and deported to Rangoon, in British-controlled Burma.

As the British government took control, Victoria gave the existing kingdoms and principalities of India the option of joining her union. The realms that did so were referred to as Princely States, and they kept their own king or ruler as a figurehead and liaison between the state and the British government. Realms who did not wish to join eventually did so by force, losing their independence altogether. These were called the Provinces. Provinces were ruled directly by British administrators. In effect, Great Britain ended up with all of India under its authority, though about 40 percent of that territory was comprised of Princely States. These included Rajasthan, Hyderabad, Jammu and Kashmir, Mysore, and the Baluchistan states.

Within the first four years of official British rule over the vast majority of the subcontinent, the foreign administration not only enacted the Indian Councils Act but dealt with a famine in the Doab region. The former established a working administration in which there were several main departments: revenue, military, law, and finance. The second event was not so simple, and between 1860 and 1861, an estimated two million people starved to death. News of the horrid conditions and unprecedented deaths spread internationally. The following excerpt came from *The New York Times* on March 30, 1861:

> From 400 to 500 deaths a day seems a too moderate computation. Under the brazen sky, young and old, the feeble and the strong, lie down on the iron ground and die. The streets of Delhi are packed with gaunt, despairing wretches, whom a handful of rice would reprieve. Women and children, too weak to eat the food that pity puts into their mouths, expire in the effort to swallow it. Mothers in Travancore sell their pretty children for sixpence, or a bowl of rice, to low-caste buyers --